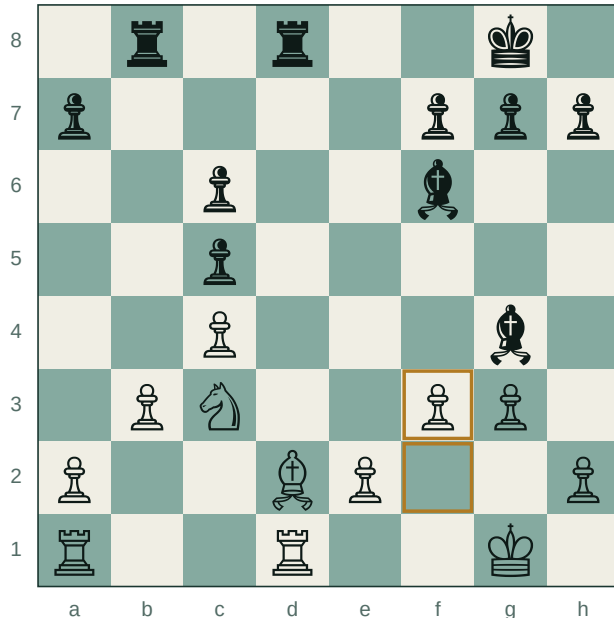


Capture the defender: Black, move 19

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 19.f3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19...Rxd2 20. Rxd2 Bxc3 21. Rad1 Bxd2

19...Rxd2 The rook captures the bishop on d2. Recorded reply: **20.Rxd2**.

20...Bxc3 The bishop captures the knight on c3. From c3 it attacks rook on d2 and rook on a1. Recorded reply: **21.Rad1**.

21...Bxd2 The bishop captures the rook on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -1 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.